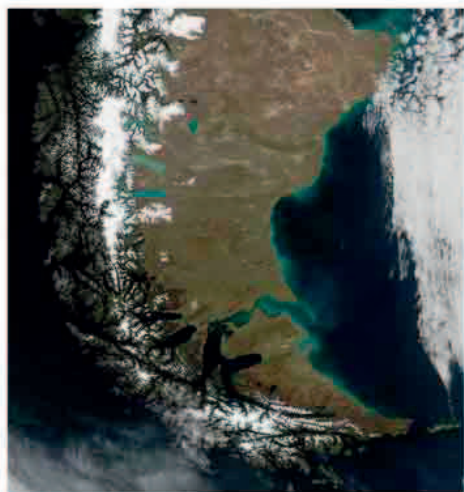


Making mountains

Mountains are built by the same forces that cause earthquakes. Colliding plates crumple continental crust into ranges of fold mountains. When crust is pulled apart, some pieces slip downward, leaving high walls of rock on each side. Molten magma oozing up from below can solidify in great masses of hard rock that may be exposed if softer covering rock is worn away.



COLLISION ZONES

When oceanic crust plows beneath a slab of continental crust, the edge of the continent crumples into ranges of fold mountains. This is the force that is raising the Andes mountain range in South America. A similar process built the Rocky Mountains of North America more than 35 million years ago.

◀ UPLIFTED

The snow-capped Andes are being pushed up by the Pacific ocean floor grinding eastward beneath the western side of South America.

CRASHING CONTINENTS

If two continents collide, this can cause massive folding and thickening of the crust. This is happening today in Asia, where the Indian Plate is plowing north into the Eurasian Plate at the rate of about 1 in (2.5 cm) per year.

▼ ROOF OF THE WORLD

The collision of the Indian and Eurasian Plates has formed the Himalayas, Earth's highest mountains.

